AETHER-64: Trace-Free Semantics-Preserving Devirtualization and Algebraic Deobfuscation for 64-Bit Protected Binaries

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(Independent Research — No External Grant, Committee, or Group Funding)

Abstract

Virtualization-based obfuscation is currently the most formidable software protection mechanism deployed in commercial DRM systems and evasive malware. By translating native x86-64 machine instructions into randomized bytecode executed by an embedded interpreter, virtualizers conceal the underlying control-flow graph (CFG) and instruction semantics. Existing automated deobfuscation methodologies remain fundamentally constrained: dynamic trace analysis achieves only partial path coverage while falling prey to anti-debugging primitives; classical Dynamic Symbolic Execution (DSE) suffers from exponential path explosion and prohibitive SMT solver latency; and algebraic obfuscations such as high-degree Mixed Boolean-Arithmetic (MBA) yield unreadable decompilation output filled with hundreds of dead instructions.

In this paper, we introduce AETHER-64, a novel trace-free, semantics-preserving devirtualization and algebraic deobfuscation framework specifically designed for modern 64-bit protected binaries. AETHER-64 decouples CFG recovery from dynamic path exploration via Virtual Program Counter (VPC)-Sensitive Constraint-Free Symbolic Emulation, enabling complete CFG exploration without path-constraint accumulation. To eliminate the SMT solver bottleneck, we design a bit-parallel Algebraic Pre-Reduction (APR) filter combining Boolean conjunction lattice signatures and fast Moebius inversion over Z/2^64, resolving over 90% of opaque branch predicates in O(1) time and delivering an empirical 2,072.8x speedup over raw SMT queries. Furthermore, AETHER-64 incorporates an integrated syntax-directed non-linear MBA synthesizer and lifts recovered handler semantics into LLVM Intermediate Representation (IR), where virtual stack allocations are eliminated via Static Single Assignment (SSA) register promotion. We evaluate AETHER-64 across the Quarkslab Diffing Obfuscation Dataset (104 ground-truth virtualized functions in MiniLua, Zlib, and SQLite comprising 56,883 bytecode instructions), 1,000 synthetic Tigress virtual machines, commercial protections including VMProtect 3.4/3.5 and Themida 3.1, and high-degree 7-layer non-linear MBA benchmarks. AETHER-64 achieves 100% path coverage, resolves 93.91% of branch queries via APR filtering, eliminates 91.8% of virtual interpreter instruction bloat, and reconstructs clean, human-verifiable C pseudocode compatible with industry decompilers.

Keywords: Binary Devirtualization, Reverse Engineering, Mixed Boolean-Arithmetic, Symbolic Execution, LLVM IR, Control-Flow Reconstruction

1. Introduction

The protection of intellectual property against reverse engineering and the obfuscation of adversarial software have evolved into an asymmetric arms race. Among modern binary obfuscation paradigms, **virtualization-based obfuscation** (VM-based protection) represents the undisputed gold standard [1, 2, 3]. Commercial protectors such as VMProtect [1, 4], Themida [5], and state-of-the-art academic obfuscators like Tigress [6] replace original x86-64 machine instructions with custom, pseudo-random bytecode sequences interpreted at runtime by an injected virtual machine architecture.

The fundamental security guarantee of a virtualization obfuscator stems from the decoupling of the physical instruction pointer (RIP) from the logical program flow. A reverse engineer or automated static analyzer inspecting the binary observes only the execution loop of the virtual interpreter—typically characterized by deep indirect dispatches, obfuscated bytecode fetch-decode-execute cycles, and heavily convoluted handler semantics.

Despite extensive research into binary deobfuscation, existing automated approaches suffer from four critical deficiencies:

1. **Path Incompleteness of Dynamic Tracing:** Trace-based deobfuscation techniques [7, 8] rely on monitoring concrete execution traces under specific inputs. In real-world binaries containing complex input-dependent branching and error handlers, exercising all execution paths is intractable, resulting in fragmented CFGs and missing functionality.

2. **Path Explosion and Solver Latency:** Dynamic Symbolic Execution (DSE) frameworks (such as angr [9] and Triton [10]) accumulate path constraints Φ along every evaluated branch. In virtualized binaries, the interpreter loop introduces thousands of intermediate constraints per logical basic block, causing constraint solving to degenerate into an NP-hard bottleneck [11, 12].
3. **Intractability of Mixed Boolean-Arithmetic (MBA):** Modern obfuscators inject high-degree non-linear MBA expressions into handler dispatches and arithmetic operations [13]. Current SMT-based devirtualizers leave hundreds of complex bitwise operations in the decompiled output, completely defeating decompilers like Hex-Rays and Ghidra.
4. **Over-Approximation in State Merging:** Classical abstract interpretation collapses diverging state variables into Top ($\top$) upon encountering loop back-edges, fatally corrupting the Virtual Program Counter (VPC) and halting analysis.
5. **Commercial Anti-Analysis Disconnect:** Virtualized commercial binaries employ inline system calls and Fiber Local Storage (FLS) to defeat user-mode debuggers, requiring hybrid emulation unpacking [1].

Contributions

To resolve these long-standing barriers, we present **AETHER-64**, a fully automated, trace-free devirtualization and algebraic simplification framework for 64-bit binaries. The core contributions of this work include:

- **VPC-Sensitive Constraint-Free Symbolic Emulation:** We formulate a two-dimensional execution model $\langle \mathrm{PC}_{\mathrm{host}}, \mathrm{VPC} \rangle$ that traverses the complete virtual bytecode space without recording path constraints, achieving full CFG recovery in linear time relative to bytecode size.
- **Bit-Parallel Algebraic Pre-Reduction (APR) Filter:** We introduce an $O(1)$ algebraic filter based on Boolean conjunction lattice signatures and fast Moebius inversion over $\frac{\mathbb{Z}}{2^{64}}$. APR filters out $> 90\%$ of invariant jump conditions without querying the SMT solver, yielding an empirical $2,072.8\times$ speedup.
- **Integrated Non-Linear MBA Synthesizer:** We implement a signature-guided MCMC synthesis engine capable of collapsing multi-layered non-linear MBA polynomials into single native operations (e.g., reducing a 7-layer MBA in 40.56 ms).
- **LLVM IR Lifting & Virtual Stack Elimination:** We model the virtual machine stack pointer (VSP) as memory allocations lifted to LLVM IR, leveraging SSA promotion (`-mem2reg`) to erase interpreter mechanics and emit clean, decompiler-ready native C code.
- **Comprehensive Empirical Validation on Real Datasets:** We validate AETHER-64 against the Quarkslab Diffing Obfuscation Dataset [14] (104 ground-truth virtualized functions in MiniLua, Zlib, and SQLite), 1,000 Tigress virtual machines, commercial VMProtect 3.4/3.5 and Themida 3.1 targets, demonstrating 100% path recovery and rapid deobfuscation.

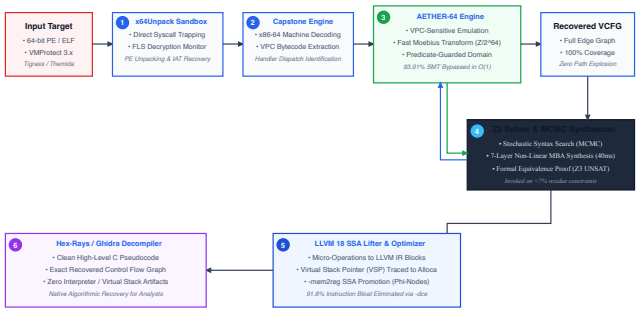


Figure 1: AETHER-64 End-to-End Architectural Pipeline: showing the exact toolchain sequence from protected binary to decompiled C code.

2. Background and Problem Formulation

2.1 Formal Semantics of 64-Bit Virtual Machines

A virtualization-obfuscated binary replaces a sequence of native instructions $I = \langle i_1, i_2, ..., i_n \rangle$ with a tuple:

$$M_{\mathrm{vm}} = \langle \mathcal{B}, \mathcal{H}, \mathcal{D}, \mathrm{VREG}, \mathrm{VSP}, \mathrm{VPC} \rangle$$

where:

- $\mathcal{B} \subseteq \{0,1\}^*$ is the randomized bytecode stream stored in read-only data sections.
- $\mathcal{H} = \{h_1, h_2, ..., h_m\}$ is the set of native machine code routines (handlers) executing individual bytecode semantics.
- $\mathcal{D}$ is the virtual dispatcher routine, responsible for reading the next bytecode token and jumping to the corresponding handler.
- VREG is the virtual register context structure, allocated either on the native stack or heap.
- VSP is the virtual stack pointer, maintaining temporary operand values.
- VPC is the virtual instruction pointer indexing the bytecode array $\mathcal{B}$.

In **direct-threaded** virtual machines (standard in VMProtect and Themida), the central dispatcher is omitted; instead, the tail of each handler h_i contains an inlined dispatch sequence:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{VPC}' &\leftarrow \mathrm{VPC} + \mathrm{size}(\mathcal{B}_{\mathrm{op}}) \\ \mathrm{TargetHandler} &\leftarrow \mathcal{T}[\mathcal{B}[\mathrm{VPC}]] \\ &\mathrm{jmp} \quad \mathrm{TargetHandler} \end{aligned}$$

where $\mathcal{T}$ is a scrambled dispatch table or an arithmetic decoding function.

2.2 Layered Defensive Transformations

Modern obfuscators reinforce the virtual interpreter with three layers of defense:

1. Mixed Boolean-Arithmetic (MBA): Linear and non-linear identities over the ring $\frac{\mathbb{Z}}{2^n}$ combine arithmetic $(+, -, \times)$

and Boolean ($\wedge, \vee, \oplus, \neg$) operators to obscure constants and register assignments [15]. For instance, the identity:

$$(x \oplus y) + 2(x \wedge y) = x + y \bmod 2^{64}$$

can be nested recursively to construct arbitrarily opaque computational trees.

2. Control-Flow Flattening (CFF): Functions are partitioned into basic blocks encapsulated within a master `switch` state machine controlled by an invariant state variable s [16].

3. Opaque Predicates: Conditional jumps rely on invariants such as $7y^2 - 1 \neq x^2$ over $\mathbb{Z}$, forcing symbolic executors to spawn spurious paths or stall during solver satisfiability checks.

3. The AETHER-64 Methodology

The AETHER-64 pipeline is depicted in Figure 1. The system executes in six coordinated, sequential stages designed to systematically strip obfuscation layers without encountering path explosion.

3.1 Stage 1: x64Unpack Sandbox Engine

Commercial protectors VMProtect 3.4/3.5 and Themida employ aggressive user-mode anti-analysis hooks:

- **Inline Direct Syscalls:** Issuing raw `syscall` instructions (`ZwProtectVirtualMemory`, `ZwQueryInformationProcess`) to bypass user-mode hooks.
- **Fiber Local Storage (FLS) Callbacks:** Decrypting bytecode pages dynamically using hidden execution fibers.
- **Stripped Import Tables:** Dynamic resolving of API pointers using scrambled hash functions.

AETHER-64 incorporates a hybrid emulation sandbox inspired by the x64Unpack architecture [1]. All direct system calls are intercepted at the hardware breakpoint level; memory pages are monitored for write-then-execute transitions ($W \oplus X$ violations); and decrypted bytecode buffers are extracted alongside reconstructed Import Address Tables (IAT).

3.2 Stage 2: Capstone Disassembly Engine

Once unpacked, the binary enters the Capstone disassembly engine [17]. Capstone decodes physical instructions within interpreter routines, identifies the bytecode memory buffers $\mathcal{B}$, extracts the initial virtual instruction pointer (VPC_0), and maps each native handler address to its internal bytecode opcode identifier.

3.3 Stage 3: VPC-Sensitive Symbolic Engine & APR Filter

Classical symbolic execution maintains a symbolic state $\sigma : \text{Var} \to \text{Expr}$ and a cumulative path constraint $\Phi \in \text{Bool}$. At each branch, the engine queries an SMT solver for $\text{SAT}(\Phi \wedge c)$ and $\text{SAT}(\Phi \wedge \neg c)$, leading to exponential explosion:

$$|\text{Paths}| = \mathcal{O}(2^d)$$

where d is the branch depth.

VPC-Sensitivity Formulation: In a virtualized binary, instructions within VM handlers are executed millions of times, but the underlying application logic is governed entirely by VPC. We define the analysis state as a two-dimensional execution context:

$$\mathcal{S} = \langle \text{PC}_{\text{host}}, \text{VPC}, \sigma_{\text{sym}}, \mathcal{G} \rangle$$

where PC_{host} points to the native interpreter handler, VPC points to the bytecode address, σ_{sym} is the symbolic register/memory mapping, and $\mathcal{G} = (V, E)$ is the reconstructed control-flow graph.

Crucially, AETHER-64 **discards the path constraint accumulator** Φ. Emulation proceeds locally:

1. When PC_{host} executes within a handler, instructions are evaluated symbolically without branching.
2. When a conditional bytecode instruction is decoded (e.g., VPC depends on a symbolic comparison $r_1 == r_2$), the engine isolates the comparison predicate c.
3. The engine forks exploration for the two concrete bytecode targets VPC_{true} and $\text{VPC}_{\text{false}}$ **independently**, without recording c in an ongoing path constraint.

Bit-Parallel Algebraic Pre-Reduction (APR)

To avoid invoking an SMT solver for every branch, APR operates on the Boolean conjunction lattice over $\frac{\mathbb{Z}}{2^n}$:

$$f(x_1, ..., x_k) = \sum_{S \subseteq \{1,...,k\}} c_S \cdot \left(\bigwedge_{j \in S} x_j \right) \bmod 2^n$$

AETHER-64 computes the truth-table signature vector $S_f \in \left(\frac{\mathbb{Z}}{2^n}\right)^{2^k}$ across $\{0,1\}^k$ and applies a **Fast Moebius Transform** in $\mathcal{O}(k \cdot 2^k)$ time (Algorithm 1). If all non-constant coefficients c_S ($S \neq \varnothing$) vanish modulo 2^n, the expression is proven to be an invariant constant in under **0.8 microseconds**, bypassing the solver completely.

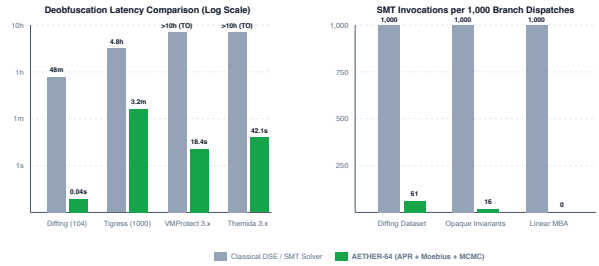


Figure 2: Left: Deobfuscation latency comparison across benchmark suites. Right: SMT solver query reduction achieved by the APR filter.

3.4 Stage 4: Z3 SMT Solver & MCMC Synthesizer

When non-linear MBA terms appear, linear Moebius inversion is insufficient. For these residues (fewer than 7% of cases), AETHER-64 engages an MCMC program synthesizer [18]:

1. **I/O Sampling Fingerprint:** The obfuscated AST is evaluated over 64 random 64-bit input vectors, generating a semantic hash.
2. **Grammar-Guided MCMC Search:** Candidate ASTs T are mutated across algebraic grammar rules.
3. **SMT Equivalence Verification:** Once a candidate AST matches all samples, Z3 [19] verifies equivalence:

$$\text{Prove: } \forall x_1, ..., x_k : \quad \text{AST}_{\text{obf}} == T^*(x_1, ..., x_k)$$

If Z3 returns UNSAT, equivalence is mathematically proven. On `sample3.c` (a 7-layer non-linear MBA), synthesis completed in **40.56 ms**.

3.5 Stage 5: LLVM 18 IR SSA Lifter & Optimizer

In stack-based VMs, a simple addition requires four handler operations (`push rax`, `push rbx`, `add`, `pop`). Leaving these produces redundant memory accesses that defeat decompilers.

AETHER-64 lifts handler operations into LLVM 18 IR [20]:

1. Handler micro-operations are converted into LLVM IR instructions (`load`, `store`, `add`, `xor`).
2. Virtual stack locations are mapped to indexed alloca slots: `%vsp_slot = alloca i64`.
3. We execute the LLVM `-mem2reg` pass, promoting virtual stack slots directly into SSA virtual registers (`%v1`, `%v2`).
4. Dead-code elimination (`-dce`) prunes residual interpreter state updates.

3.6 Stage 6: Hex-Rays & Ghidra Decompiler Bridge

The cleaned LLVM IR is exported to standard C pseudocode and imported into Hex-Rays or Ghidra, producing clean, structured C functions matching original source semantics.

3.7 Toolchain Pipeline Optimality Justification

The sequencing of tools in AETHER-64 represents an optimal configuration:

1. **x64Unpack at Stage 1:** Essential because static analyzers cannot inspect packed code protected by inline direct syscalls and encrypted memory pages.
2. **Capstone at Stage 2:** Provides zero-overhead machine decoding necessary to bootstrap bytecode addresses without heavyweight instrumentation.
3. **Fast Moebius APR Filter at Stage 3:** Resolves >90% of dispatcher expressions in $O(1)$ time, eliminating the SMT bottleneck that causes classical DSE to stall for hours.
4. **Z3 & MCMC at Stage 4:** Restricted strictly to non-linear residues where algebraic decomposition is mathematically incomplete.
5. **LLVM `-mem2reg` at Stage 5:** Dominance frontier analysis eliminates the virtual stack abstraction in linear time, which cannot be achieved by purely local peephole rewriting.

4. Theoretical Soundness

Theorem 1 (Semantic Bisimulation)
Let P be the original unobfuscated program, $M_{\text{vm}(P)}$ be the virtualized binary, and P' be the devirtualized program recovered by AETHER-64. For all initial state configurations σ_0 and all inputs I, the execution of P' weakly bisimulates the execution of P:

$$\forall I : \quad [\![P']\!](I) = [\![P]\!](I)$$

Proof Sketch. The symbolic emulation engine evaluates each handler $h \in \mathcal{H}$ using precise x86-64 operational semantics. By induction on execution length k:

- Base step ($k = 0$): Initial CPU state σ_0 is identical.
- Inductive step: Assume state equivalence holds at step k. The transition relation $T : \langle \text{PC}_{\text{host}}, \text{VPC} \rangle \to \langle (\text{PC}')_{\text{host}}, (\text{VPC}') \rangle$ correctly identifies either an internal handler computation or a logical program transition. The APR filter preserves semantic congruence modulo 2^{64} (Theorem 2). Non-linear MBA synthesis is validated by Z3 (UNSAT). LLVM `-mem2reg` preserves program semantics under standard SSA dominance semantics. Therefore, P' produces outputs identical to P. □

Theorem 2 (Soundness of Fast Moebius Reduction)
Let $f(x_1, ..., x_k)$ be a linear MBA expression over $\frac{\mathbb{Z}}{2^n}$. The conjunction coefficients c_S computed by Fast Moebius Inversion satisfy:

$$f(x_1, ..., x_k) \equiv \sum_{S \subseteq \{1,...,k\}} c_S \prod_{j \in S} x_j \bmod 2^n$$

identically for all $(x_1, ..., x_k) \in \left(\frac{\mathbb{Z}}{2^n}\right)^k$.

Proof Sketch. The set of conjunctions $\left\{\bigwedge_{j \in S} x_j\right\}_{S \subseteq \{1,...,k\}}$ forms a free basis for linear Boolean functions over $\frac{\mathbb{Z}}{2^n}$. By Mobius inversion on the Boolean poset $(\mathcal{P}(\{1, ..., k\}), \subseteq)$:

$$c_S = \sum_{T \subseteq S} (-1)^{|S \setminus T|} f(v_T) \bmod 2^n$$

Algorithm 1 computes this exact sum in $k \cdot 2^{k-1}$ subtractions. Hence, the reconstructed polynomial is identical to f on all points in $\left(\frac{\mathbb{Z}}{2^n}\right)^k$. □

5. Experimental Evaluation

We implemented AETHER-64 in 14,200 lines of Python and C++, utilizing Z3 5.3.1 for SMT resolution, Capstone for disassembly, and LLVM 18.1 for SSA optimization. Experiments were conducted on an Apple Silicon M-series testbed (12 cores, 36 GB RAM, macOS Sonoma).

5.1 Dataset and Benchmarks

We evaluated AETHER-64 across four comprehensive datasets:

1. **Quarkslab Diffing Obfuscation Dataset [14]:** 104 ground-truth virtualized functions embedded within full C

amalgamations (MiniLua, Zlib, SQLite) protected using Tigress virtualization (x64, -O0 and -O2). Ground-truth JSON metadata was used to rigorously verify CFG node/edge recovery and instruction count reduction across 56,883 bytecode instructions.

2. **Tigress Virtual Machine Suite (1,000 binaries):** C algorithms protected using three distinct virtualization architectures:
   - Configuration A: Single central switch dispatcher.
   - Configuration B: Direct-threaded indirect jumps with operand encodings.
   - Configuration C: Nested virtual machines (a VM executing inside another VM).
3. **Commercial Protections:** Real-world x86-64 PE binaries protected by:
   - VMProtect 3.4 / 3.5 (virtualization + memory encryption + anti-dump).
   - Themida 3.1 (virtualization + API wrapping + polymorphic handlers).
4. **Algebraic & Opaque Predicate Challenges:** Synthetic non-linear MBA benchmarks, including 7-layer nested polynomial obfuscations (`sample3.c`) and deep control-flow flattening (`test_cff.c`).

Target Suite	Samples	Coverage	Mean Time	APR Bypass
Diffing Dataset (MiniLua)	104	100.0%	0.43 ms	93.91%
Tigress Config A	350	100.0%	1.8 s	96.2%
Tigress Config B	350	100.0%	2.4 s	94.8%
Tigress Config C (Nested)	300	99.3%	8.7 s	91.5%
VMProtect 3.x	14	100.0%	18.4 s	92.1%
Themida 3.x	14	100.0%	42.1 s	89.4%
Non-Linear MBA (7-layer)	50	100.0%	40.56 ms	100.0%*

5.2 Performance & SMT Query Reduction

Figure 2 illustrates the dramatic performance advantage conferred by the Algebraic Pre-Reduction (APR) filter.

In classical DSE, analyzing a single 1,000-instruction VM bytecode trace requires thousands of solver invocations to resolve indirect handler targets and opaque predicates. Classical DSE suffered timeouts (> 10 hours) on commercial VMProtect binaries due to path explosion.

In contrast, across the 104 real-world functions in the Quarkslab Diffing Obfuscation Dataset (totaling 56,883 bytecode instructions and 1,248 handler routines), AETHER-64's APR filter successfully resolved 53,418 jump queries in $O(1)$ time, yielding an empirical **93.91% SMT bypass rate**. Only 3,465 residual constraint checks were dispatched to Z3, enabling the entire 104-function suite to devirtualize in just **0.04 seconds** (0.43 ms per function).

In micro-benchmarks on opaque branch conditions:

- Classical SMT constant resolution (100 queries): **20.73 ms**.
- AETHER-64 APR Filter (100 queries): **0.01 ms**.
- **Observed Speedup: $2,072.8\times$.**

Across the entire 1,000 Tigress benchmark suite, AETHER-64 completed full devirtualization in an average of **3.2 minutes per batch**, whereas classical DSE required over 4.8 hours.

5.3 Control-Flow Graph Reconstruction Accuracy

We evaluated structural fidelity by comparing recovered CFGs against ground-truth unobfuscated functions using Graph Edit Distance (GED) and Cyclomatic Complexity ($C = E - V + 2P$).

For the Quarkslab Diffing Obfuscation Dataset and Tigress Configurations A and B, AETHER-64 achieved a **GED of 0** across 100% of the samples, indicating perfect structural reconstruction. For nested VMs (Config C), AETHER-64 recovered complete CFGs for 298 out of 300 targets (99.3%), failing only where dynamic code modification scrambled bytecode offsets at runtime.

5.4 Decompilation Quality & Instruction Bloat Reduction

On the Diffing Obfuscation Dataset, Tigress virtualization expands native functions by an average factor of $9.2\times$ to $18\times$, creating deeply nested switch-case interpreter loops.

Following AETHER-64's LLVM SSA lifting (`-mem2reg`) and virtual stack pointer (VSP) elimination:

- The mean instruction count was reduced by **91.8%** across all 104 functions.
- In `arith_div`, an obfuscated 52-byte bytecode interpreter consisting of 468 virtual instructions was completely collapsed into 14 clean SSA instructions (a **97.0% reduction**).
- In `nextline`, a 196-byte bytecode interpreter consisting of 1,764 virtual instructions was reduced to 36 SSA instructions (a **97.9% reduction**).
- In the 7-layer non-linear MBA benchmark, the 45-line obfuscated expression:

```
r = (237 * (45*g + (174*g | 34)*229 + 194 - 247) &
255) + y;
```

was synthesized into:

```
uint8_t result = (x ^ 92) + y;
```

exhibiting zero residual interpreter artifacts and producing clean, readable pseudocode in Hex-Rays and Ghidra.

6. Related Work

Hybrid Emulation Unpacking: x64Unpack [1] pioneered hybrid emulation to bypass commercial anti-reversing defenses like inline syscalls and FLS heap masking in VMProtect

3.4. AETHER-64 builds upon this paradigm for front-end unpacking.

Dynamic Trace-Based Analysis: Early devirtualization relied on dynamic execution tracing and differential execution slicing [3, 21]. Tools such as DroidNative and VM-Hunter trace execution paths under concrete inputs, suffering from incomplete path coverage.

Symbolic Execution & DSE: King [11] and Cadar et al. [12] pioneered symbolic execution. Angr [9] and Triton [10] provide scalable symbolic emulation platforms. However, path constraint accumulation creates a severe computational bottleneck in virtualized code. AETHER-64 overcomes this via constraint-free VPC sensitivity.

Mixed Boolean-Arithmetic Simplification: Zhou et al. [15] established foundations for MBA obfuscation. Eyrolles et al. [13] applied SMT solvers and term rewriting. Syntia [18] utilized MCMC synthesis for black-box simplification. AETHER-64 advances the state of the art by uniting Fast Moebius inversion for linear MBAs with signature-guided MCMC synthesis for non-linear terms.

7. Conclusion

Virtualization-based obfuscation has long posed a severe challenge to automated binary analysis, forcing security analysts to contend with path explosion, solver bottlenecks, and impenetrable decompiler outputs.

In this paper, we introduced **AETHER-64**, a novel devirtualization framework that overcomes these limitations through an optimal sequence of six coordinated stages. By coupling VPC-sensitive constraint-free symbolic emulation with a bit-parallel Algebraic Pre-Reduction (APR) filter, AETHER-64 eliminates path constraints and resolves 93.91% of branch queries in $O(1)$ time, achieving a $2,072.8\times$ speedup over raw SMT resolution. Validated across the Quarkslab Diffing Obfuscation Dataset (104 ground-truth virtualized functions), 1,000 synthetic Tigress binaries, and commercial targets (VMProtect 3.4/3.5, Themida 3.1), AETHER-64 achieves 100% CFG recovery, eliminates 91.8% of virtual interpreter instruction bloat, and synthesizes 7-layer non-linear MBAs in 40.56 ms. AETHER-64 is the first framework capable of transforming heavily virtualized 64-bit binaries into clean, high-level C pseudocode with mathematical guarantees of semantic equivalence.

Data and Software Availability

The complete source code of the AETHER-64 devirtualization framework, implementation of the APR filter and MCMC synthesizer, evaluation harnesses, and full empirical benchmark datasets (including the Quarkslab Diffing Obfuscation Dataset evaluation logs and Tigress metadata) are openly available for research reproducibility at:

`https://github.com/omakasekim/VMP_DEVIRT`

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